

Shannon L. Coleman, PhD

Experience Research and Strategy Leader • AI Product Measurement • Regulated & Enterprise Markets

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[Ground Truth \(Substack\)](#) | Writing on AI product measurement, capability evaluation, and research practice

[The Capability Question](#) | An AI-powered research design tool for measuring what AI enablement does to human judgment

SUMMARY

Experience research and strategy leader with 15+ years across DoD modernization, enterprise AI, regulated HealthTech, and FinTech. Comes into complex, ambiguous situations, figures out what is actually true, and moves organizations toward better decisions. Equally fluent in a regression model and a 90-minute interview. Active Secret Clearance.

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

- **\$15B DoD Acquisition:** Drove the **\$15B** Advana multi-vendor recompile, the largest defense analytics platform contract in recent history, through a multi-method research program across **1,382** enterprise users
- **XLA Standards in \$5.7B Contracts:** Set the first contract-level UX performance standard for **800,000+** personnel by defining and operationalizing Experience Level Agreement standards embedded into **\$5.7B** Air Force EITaaS vendor contracts
- **Commander's Commendation:** Awarded U.S. Air Force Commander's Challenge Coin for shifting IT modernization to a user-centric service model, setting **foundational standards for DAF digital transformation**
- **950+ Participant Panel Built from Zero:** Reduced external recruitment spend to **\$0** and cut study recruitment timelines by at least **2 weeks** per study by building and scaling a **950+** participant proprietary research panel under HIPAA-adjacent and FDIC-regulated constraints
- **Trust-Transfer Model:** Contributed to an AI health platform's first **six-figure** service agreement and growth from users in the hundreds to **16,000+** by developing a B2B2C go-to-market framework reorienting channel strategy toward self-funded employers, unions, and advocacy organizations

EXPERIENCE

Principal Research & Strategy Advisor | Coleman Advisory

2022–Present

Independent consulting practice focused on mixed methods UX research and product strategy for early-stage HealthTech and FinTech platforms in regulated markets, working directly with founders and executive teams.

- Grew an AI-powered health platform from users in the hundreds to **16,000+** and contributed to their first **six-figure** service agreement by surfacing the “Not for Me” Paradox and a trust gap at onboarding; the resulting Trust-Transfer Model reoriented channel strategy toward self-funded employers, unions, and advocacy organizations
- Accelerated compliance approval cycles by **3 weeks** and eliminated late-stage engineering rework by reframing UX and compliance as a single workstream across a Web3 FinTech engagement, aligning onboarding and transaction flows with regulatory risk from the start
- Prevented approximately **2 sprints** of misaligned engineering work and improved task completion confidence by **35%** by catching a churn-driving score-first UX pattern in a **6-user** prototype test before development began

Research & Strategy Lead, DoD | Isobar Public Sector

2022–2025

Principal researcher and strategist for two large-scale DoD programs serving a combined 900,000+ users and personnel.

Advana | DoD CDAO Enterprise Analytics Platform

- Established the evidentiary foundation for all subsequent platform and roadmap recommendations through a multi-method research program across **1,382** enterprise users, spanning survey, interview, card sort, tree test, and two rounds of usability testing
- Directly informed a DoD-level development pause for infrastructure improvements by surfacing **six** simultaneous failure modes and reframing discrete issues as a structural challenge on a platform that had scaled faster than its architecture, its UX, and its organizational support model
- Diagnosed a content-findability crisis affecting **36%** of users as an information architecture failure rather than a user education problem, delivering the sitemap, navigation redesign, and content model to resolve it
- Contributed to the **\$15B** multi-vendor recompile and **two** product roadmaps by delivering findings and strategic recommendations directly to the Chief Experience Architect and Chief Product Officer

Air Force EITaaS | Enterprise IT Modernization (\$5.7B program)

- Drove **84%** faster system startup, **59%** faster data transfer, and **92%** reduction in security event workload by developing a persona and workflow research framework across **nine** deployment sites, establishing the segmentation foundation that enabled XLA standard definition

- Institutionalized UX performance expectations for **800,000+** personnel by defining and operationalizing Experience Level Agreement (XLA) standards embedded into **\$5.7B** vendor contracts
- Validated the program model before the Air Force committed to scaling by measuring IT satisfaction rising to **74/100** against a baseline of **44** at comparable pre-transition bases, with speed satisfaction at **73** versus mid-**40s** elsewhere
- **Awarded** U.S. Air Force Commander's Challenge Coin for shifting IT modernization to a user-centric service model, setting **foundational standards for DAF digital transformation**

Research & Strategy Analyst | Crowley Webb / Praxis

2020–2022

- Reduced external recruitment spend to **\$0** and cut study recruitment timelines by at least **2 weeks** per study by building and scaling a **950+** participant research panel from zero under HIPAA-adjacent and FDIC-regulated constraints
- Increased **trial recruitment signups** for F500 pharmaceutical clients including Pfizer, Eli Lilly, Merck, J&J, and AbbVie by conducting qualitative interviews, large-scale surveys, social listening, and patient experience research that directly informed site selection adjustments and messaging changes
- Improved **recruitment conversion** across concurrent **multi-million-dollar** Phase II/III campaigns by applying quantitative analysis to real-time performance insights, driving site selection adjustments, messaging changes, and budget reallocation
- Reduced overall project timelines by **2–4 days** per study and eliminated redundant overhead by managing research operations for a 7–10 person team and standardizing recruitment workflows across concurrent client programs

Doctoral Researcher | University at Buffalo, Psychology & Quantitative Methods

2014–2019

- Led multi-year mixed methods longitudinal research integrating qualitative and advanced quantitative modeling to identify dropout risk patterns in digital learning environments; applied survival analysis and logistic regression to high-dimensional behavioral datasets
- Managed a **25+** person research operations team, improving interrater reliability by **60%+**, reducing costly re-coding cycles, producing consistently defensible findings, and strengthening the evidentiary basis for policy recommendations presented at the White House

Early Career

- **Fisher-Price:** Informed a **4-product** category launch and evaluated **100+** concepts and prototypes across multiple product lines by leading usability and developmental research in partnership with Product, Engineering, and Design
- **Segmedica, Inc.:** Designed and analyzed a **35,000+** response national survey across **30+** pharmaceutical brands, packaged into a proprietary strategic research product

EDUCATION

PhD & MA, Psychology & Quantitative Methods — University at Buffalo, State University of New York
BS, Education — Fredonia, State University of New York

CORE EXPERTISE

Research Methods Mixed methods research, usability testing and prototype validation, in-depth interviews and contextual inquiry, survey design and quantitative analysis, longitudinal and behavioral data modeling, survival analysis, logistic regression, A/B testing

Tools Qualtrics, dscout, Figma, Miro, UserTesting, Optimal Workshop, Dovetail, R, SPSS, Tableau, Power BI, Azure SQL, GA4, Google Search Console

Product & Strategy Product roadmapping, strategic framework development, go-to-market research, XLA and CX measurement, persona and segmentation frameworks, information architecture, Agile research integration

AI Tools Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Dovetail AI, Notion AI, Otter.ai, Miro Assist

Research Operations Research program design, panel development and management, research ops standardization, cross-functional research leadership, compliance-driven research (HIPAA, GDPR, ISO 27001:2022)

Platforms Jira, Confluence, ServiceNow, GitHub

Domains AI products, HealthTech, GovTech / DoD, enterprise platforms, regulated and compliance-driven systems, classified environments, Web3 / FinTech